key beginnings for modern travel in the country. Rummaging through the archives of the Indian Railways and libraries and places like railway societies and heritage rail clubs, of which I have been a long-time member, I chanced upon a few documents and books—a few in the public domain and a few rare ones in the history of the Indian Railways—and this is what I found.

The story of Porto Novo is the story of the railways and steam engines in India—the story of India's first railway plans and the running of the first trains. The next few pages will run you through the historical journey of how the foundations of the railways were slowly getting laid—year-wise, sequentially, and how they spread across the continent.

The trains were coming!

THE FIRSTS—BOMBAY (1823) AND CALCUTTA (1828)

An engine is not always a locomotive or a railway engine. It is a motor or a machine that converts one form of energy into mechanical energy. In my previous book, *Halt Station India: The Dramatic Tale of the Nation's First Lines* , I quoted the very first documented references that I could find at the time of the use of steam engines in India. They pointed to Bombay (now Mumbai) in 1823 and Calcutta (now Kolkata) in 1828. Of course, these were stationary engines, used for limited purposes. While the ones in Bombay were used for a cannonball-making factory and to drive a water mill, the one in Calcutta was a nineteenth-century 'Make in India' version, made by an Indian blacksmith from Titigur—Goluk Chandra—who won a prize of ₹50 for its manufacture .

Remember, the world's first public railway—between Stockton and Darlington, England—opened in 1825. Well, the engines in Bombay had come into existence before that iconic world event in England. Reports say that as early as 1823, the Gun Carriage Factory in Colaba, then Bombay, manufacturing cannonballs and wheels, had several machines running on steam at a frantic pace. A year later, in 1824, when the world's first public railway was yet to be opened, Bombay saw another large stationary steam engine (one used for driving mills and factories) launched for public use, with cattle-driven Persian wheels pumping out water from wells to tanks. Inaugurated on 17 May 1824, this apparatus was built by the Parsi merchant